

UPROOTED
A GRAPHIC ACCOUNT OF THE STRUGGLE FOR FOREST RIGHTS
By Ita Mehrotra
WESTLAND/ CONTEXT
₹599; 144 pages

BOOKS ▼

The **Forest** People

ITA MEHROTRA documents the embattled relationship between Uttarakhand's Van Gujars and their forest home

Rich with information, perspective and detail, *Uprooted* is an intimate opus focusing on the Van Gujars: semi-nomadic Muslim buffalo herders of Uttarakhand's forested foothills. It is narrated through their voices, and evokes their struggle for land and forest rights. The artist touches all aspects of the issue: its colonial background, the nature of the forest department, the law on forest rights, the marginalisation of pastoral communities, the gender perspective, the ecological context....

Noorjahan builds her home with dried leaves, dead branches and earth; it has spaces for small birds to nest. A girl lops branches atop a tree, explaining, "We leave each tree for two years... so it grows back fully." An activist bemoans the planting of harmful invasive tree species by the forest department. Meanwhile, 'junglaat' (the forest department) and 'sarkar' (government), who allow forest resorts, highways and commercialisation, blame the pastoralists for destroying jungles. Dislocated Van Gujars are 'resettled' on agricultural land they do not know how to farm. Activists struggle to put together old papers that may prove the rights of their community.

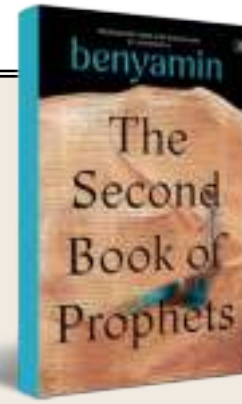
The pervasive injustice would be dispiriting but for the agency shown by the Van Gujars. Educated youngsters teach children, help women earn through their craft, and struggle for livelihood and rights in the context of a healthy forest ecology. Aamna says that pastoral communities maintain the relationship between nature and human settlements, going between these two with their animals. And Ameer hopes that the world will see that "our communities can show the way, especially when it comes to combating climate change". ■

—Juhi Saklani

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A DIFFERENT GOSPEL

Benyamin's *The Second Book of Prophets* is a fictional account of the life of Jesus Christ



THE SECOND BOOK OF PROPHETS
By Benyamin
TRANSLATED BY MINISTHY S.
SIMON & SCHUSTER INDIA
₹599; 240 pages

In Benyamin's novel *The Second Book of Prophets* (a re-imagining of the lives of Jesus Christ and his followers), there's a scene where Jesus is struggling to overcome a moment of self-doubt. The Jews think of him as a saviour foretold. But Jesus himself doesn't believe that true freedom (religious or political) can be achieved without a transformation of society, in a way that protects the poor masses. "For a man burdened with agony and suffering, there's no liberation," he thinks. The scene signals the central conceit of the book—writing the character of Jesus Christ as a young, angst-fuelled revolutionary who wants social reform not as a means to power but as an aspirational goal all by itself.

> There is a sense that Benyamin is focusing on the parts of **Christ's journey that are applicable** to modern socio-political contexts

Talking about the novel during an interview, Benyamin says, "This novel happened after I read studies on recent discoveries related to the history of Christianity, like the Dead Sea Scrolls and the Nag Hammadi library. These new texts challenge our preconceptions of what that time would have looked like." In previous novels like *Yellow Lights of Death* (2015) and *Body and Blood* (2020), Benyamin had used Christian theology and history as pivotal plot points. With *The Second Book of Prophets*, he has joined Anatole France, Jose Saramago, Norman Mailer et al, writers who produced fictionalisations of the life of Christ. There's a sense you get that Benyamin is focusing on the parts of Christ's journey that are readily applicable to modern-day socio-political contexts. "When readers get something relevant to the current context, it's easier for them to stay invested in the story," he says. "I wanted to show how Jesus was...also a social reformer. He wanted to change the way we live and not just change the way we pray." ■

—Aditya Mani Jha